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ARCHITECT OF 2024: The man with the blueprint

AMIT SHAH *Union Minister of Home Affairs*

BETTING ON THE GOOD WORK

If one had hoped that Union home minister Amit Shah would reveal his party's blueprint for the 2024 general election, as the optimistically titled session indicated, they were disappointed. At the India Today Conclave, Shah held his cards close to his chest, but expressed full confidence that the BJP will return to power, making it the first time since the 1970s that a prime minister would get elected with a full majority for three consecutive terms. What explains his confidence? "I visit every part of the country, interact with people closely and understand the pulse," he said.

Shah's confidence also stems from his conviction in the Modi government's performance, governance and service delivery to India's have-nots. Every Indian, he said, now feels a sense of pride in his country, so much so that there was not a house that did not have the national flag flying when the prime minister announced the Har Ghar Tiranga initiative.

On his own achievements, Shah said violence in Kashmir, the Northeast and left-wing terrorism had come down in the nine years of BJP rule. As for external security, Shah said that thanks to the air and surgical strikes, India, after the US and Israel, became the third nation everyone knew no one could mess with. On the stickier points, whether it was Adani, elections in Kashmir or a cabinet reshuffle, the home minister refused to be drawn into making any definitive statement. ■

Photograph by **BANDEEP SINGH**

